results. Almost every community, except the Muslims, voted overwhelmingly for the BJP. Not only was there strong upper-caste consolidation, even Other Backward Castes (OBCs), Dalits and tribals voted for the BJP in large numbers. The BJP was, at least in 2014, the new rainbow coalition.

In contrast, the 129-year-old Congress party, with its roots in the freedom movement, has been decimated, its monopoly over power challenged like never before. Even in the 1977 elections, the party at least managed to save face south of the Vindhyas. This time, Kerala is the only state where the Congress won more than ten seats. Its final tally of forty-four seats and just 19.3 per cent of the vote—the first time its percentage slipped below 20—represents a critical inflexion point in its history. The Congress performance has also been the subject of rather cruel jokes. Returning on a flight to Delhi in June, my co-passenger said, 'Looks like the national capital's temperature will soon be more than the seats the Congress has in the Lok Sabha!'

But it's not just the final result that made this 2014 election so distinctive. The election has unleashed a chain of processes—latent and overt—that could change the way elections are fought in the future. Never before has so much money been spent in fighting an Indian election—inflation doesn't just affect the price of tomatoes, it also influences the cost of an election. The BJP, bolstered by unflinching corporate support, easily outspent its rivals, but the more worrisome aspect is just the quantum of money that is now needed by every member of Parliament to win an election. Because, with every rupee donated, the IOUs need to be encashed post-election.

A candidate in Andhra Pradesh admitted to me that he needed 'at least Rs 15 to 20 crore to just stay in the fight'. The massive inflow of cash suggests that a level playing field is simply not possible any longer. It is practically impossible to win an Indian election unless you are a *crorepati* several times over, or have funders to back you. The case for state funding could not be stronger.

The brazen use of money power imperils democracy and shrinks the basket of choices before the voter. Not that every Indian voter is